

PROJECT KICKOFF

What We Build First & What It Costs to Start

We start with the part that takes bookings and makes money: the equipment catalog and online booking system. GPS tracking follows in Phase 2, once the platform is live and earning. Stack: Next.js + Node.js + PostgreSQL — modern, low-cost, and scales as the business grows.

1. What we need from the business (week 1)

- **Machine list** — every machine with make, model, year, key specs, and hourly / daily / weekly rates. Phone photos are fine to start.
- **Rental terms** — deposit amount, late-return and damage policy, with/without operator, who pays transport and fuel.
- **Business documents** — business registration certificate and bank account details — required to open the Paystack account that receives online payments.
- **One decision-maker** — who approves bookings, and who answers questions during the build.

2. Startup budget (cash needed to launch)

Item	Cost	Notes
Domain name (.com / .com.gh)	\$15-20 / year	One-time yearly
Hosting — Vercel free tier	\$0	Upgrade later if needed
Database — Neon / Supabase free tier	\$0	Upgrade ~\$25/mo at scale
Email notifications — free tier	\$0	Resend / similar
SMS credits (Arkesel / Hubtel)	~\$10 to load	Pay-as-you-go
Paystack account	Free to open	~1.95% per transaction
TOTAL CASH TO LAUNCH	Under \$50	Excludes developer time

As traffic grows, hosting and database move to roughly \$40-50/month combined — not needed on day one. GPS trackers (~\$60-150 per machine one-time + a few dollars monthly per SIM) are deferred to Phase 2, so no hardware spending needs approval today.

3. First 8 weeks of building

Weeks	What gets built	Result
Weeks 1-2	Project setup, data model, public equipment catalog with real machines and rates	Company is visible online
Weeks 3-4	Availability calendar and booking request flow	Customers can request rentals
Weeks 5-6	Admin page: view and approve bookings, mark machines under maintenance	Staff manage everything digitally
Weeks 7-8	Paystack payments (MoMo, cards) for deposits + SMS confirmations	LAUNCH — paid bookings live

4. Marketing & advertising timeline

Social media starts on day one because it is free and builds an audience while the platform is built. Paid advertising starts only at launch — ads before there is a website to book on waste money.

When	Marketing activity	Cost
Weeks 1-2	Create company accounts: Facebook, Instagram, TikTok, LinkedIn, WhatsApp Business, Google Business Profile — reserve the name everywhere	Free
Weeks 3-7	Organic content: machine photos & videos, job-site clips, behind-the-scenes — 2-3 posts per week building an audience before launch	Free
Week 8 — LAUNCH	Paid ads begin: Facebook & Instagram campaigns + boosted posts sending customers to the new website	GHS 1,500-3,000 /month
Month 3+	Add Google Ads for searches like “excavator rental Ghana”; scale only the ads that bring actual bookings	Budget grows with results

All ad accounts are opened in the company's name and funded by the company's own card — advertising spend is the company's budget, managed (not paid) by the systems manager as part of the ongoing role.

5. What comes after launch

Phase 2 adds GPS tracking, geofencing, and engine-hour billing. Phase 3 adds financial controls, reporting, and analytics. Each phase is approved separately — the business only pays for the next step once the previous one is working and earning.